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Rise of Christianity



Learning Outcomes

The learner:

- traces the origin of Christianity.
- reflects on the principles and teachings of Christianity.
- identifies similarities in the good teachings of the various forms of religion.
- discusses and analyses the relevance of Christ's teachings in the present-day context.

Warm Up!

Play a Christmas carol in the class. The children who know this carol may join and sing along.

- Why is this carol sung during Christmas?
- What are your favourite Christmas season songs?

C-2.2

THE MEDIEVAL PERIOD

The word **medieval** comes from a Latin word which means **time in the middle**. To get a clear picture of the changes that transformed the lives of people in the past, we generally divide history into **three periods**—the **Ancient** or **Early Period**, the **Medieval** or **Middle Period** and the **Modern Period**. The Medieval Period is the period between the Ancient and the Modern periods of history.

The Medieval Period in India stretches roughly from the 8th to the mid-18th century CE. It is further subdivided into two periods—the **Early Medieval Period** (8th–13th century CE) and the **Later Medieval Period** (13th–mid-18th century CE). The Later Medieval Period is usually subdivided into two phases: the **Delhi Sultanate phase** (1200–1526 CE) and the **Mughal dynasty phase** (1526–mid-18th century CE).

The Medieval Period in India does not correspond to the Medieval Period in other parts of the world. The Medieval Period in Europe roughly stretches from about

600 CE to around 1500 CE. The transition from the Ancient Period to the Medieval Period was not abrupt and sudden. It took place gradually over a period of time.

BIRTH OF CHRISTIANITY

In the middle of the 1st century BCE, the **Romans conquered Palestine**, the **homeland of the Jews**. They appointed **Herod, a puppet ruler**, under whom the **Jews suffered grave injustice and oppression**. The Jews resented their loss of freedom and looked forward, with **faith and hope**, to the coming of the **Messiah (Christ)** who would liberate them from foreign bondage and establish the **kingdom of God** in Palestine. This belief was **based on the predictions of the Prophets in the Old Testament**.

In 4 BCE, Herod died. Around 6–4 BCE, in the tiny village of **Bethlehem in Judea**, **Jesus**, believed to be the **son of God**, was

born to **Mary**. Her husband **Joseph**, a poor carpenter, was the **descendant of King David**, **Israel's most famous king** who had liberated **Israel from foreign rule 1,000 years ago**.



A tapestry in the Gallery of Tapestries, Vatican Museum, depicting The Nativity or The Birth of Jesus, who is believed to be the son of God

Jesus grew up in **Nazareth**, in northern Palestine, where he studied the Jewish scriptures. He realized that traditions and practices which violated the **Law of Moses** were being followed by certain Jewish religious groups such as the Pharisees.

The **baptism** of Jesus took place when he was about 30 years old. A **divine revelation** convinced him that the time had come for him to fulfil his mission. He had to free people from the bondage of evil and guide them on the path that would lead to the triumph of good over evil. Jesus gathered around him a band of **twelve disciples** and travelled throughout Galilee for 3 years, preaching, teaching and healing the sick.

MAIN TEACHINGS OF JESUS

The teachings of Jesus were simple, yet revolutionary. He established a code of conduct for men and women based on:

- **unconditional** love for God
- true love for one's **neighbour**

PALESTINE DURING THE TIME OF JESUS



Did You Know?

According to legend, there was once a man named John the Baptist, who was a cousin of Jesus. He used to preach and baptize people. One day, Jesus came from Nazareth and asked John to baptize him. John did not know what to say. How could he, just a regular person, baptize Jesus, the Saviour of the world? But Jesus told him that they needed to do this to fulfil all righteousness. So, John baptized Jesus. He placed his hand on Jesus's back and laid him down into the water till he was covered and then brought him back up again. And just as soon as Jesus was baptized, the sky opened up, the Holy Spirit came like a beautiful white dove and landed on Jesus's shoulder. Then a voice from heaven said, 'This is my son, love him and I am pleased with him.'

Jesus taught that there was one God who was **compassionate, loving and forgiving**. He believed that as children of God, we should mould ourselves in the image of God. We should love our neighbours, including the poor, the sinners and even our enemies; **we should help the needy and do good even to those who harm us; we should forgive our enemies and win them over with our love**. Since God loved sinners and forgave them, Jesus said that we **should do the same**. He completely rejected the 'eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth' principle.

Discuss

TP

Communication



Jesus told his followers to love their neighbours as much as they loved themselves. Discuss how easy or difficult it is to follow this advice. Do you think the world would change if everyone followed this code of conduct? Why?

Jesus's interpretation of Jewish laws **clashed** with the ideas of the Jewish religious leaders who followed the scriptures literally, and not in spirit. Jesus did not claim that his teachings were original. His mission was not to change the laws but to propagate them according to his understanding and **interpretation** of the Jewish scriptures.

Jesus's strength of character, intelligence, wisdom, compassion and simplicity attracted large crowds wherever he went. This greatly enraged the Jewish religious leaders who felt **threatened** by his growing popularity. They turned **hostile** and convinced **Pontius Pilate**, the Roman governor, that Jesus was a threat to the political authority of the **Romans**.

Jesus was **put on trial** and sentenced to death. He was nailed to a cross and **crucified**. He died a slow and painful death, firm in the belief that through suffering, he had fulfilled his mission as the **Messiah** or **Saviour**.

Know Your Sources

C-12



A painting depicting *The Last Supper*, showing Jesus Christ at the centre with his disciples. He announced that one of the disciples is going to betray him.

- The expression on the faces of the disciples convey a range of emotions. Identify these emotions that reflect their reaction to Jesus's announcement.

Critical Thinking



Palestine, but far beyond its boundaries. His life and teachings impacted the then known civilized world in an **extraordinary and revolutionary** manner.

The world would change dramatically and these changes—**social, cultural, economic and political**—would bear the imprint of Christian doctrines. The life and teachings of Jesus Christ were recorded in the **Gospels** by four of his disciples—John, Mathew, Mark and Luke. The teachings of Jesus were spread in Palestine most actively by **Peter**—the **foundation rock** of Christianity—and later by **Paul**, a convert to Christianity. Paul became one of the most powerful and enthusiastic exponents of Christianity. He travelled extensively throughout the Roman empire, preparing the grounds that would transform Christianity into a **world religion** in the future.

HOTS: Do you agree that Jesus Christ's teachings are relevant in the present-day context? Why?

Critical Thinking



For almost 300 years after the death of Jesus, Christians were a religious minority within the Roman empire, **oppressed and persecuted** by their imperial masters. In 313 CE, the status of Christianity changed dramatically. The Roman emperor, **Constantine**, won a major battle against his rival, **Maxentius**. He attributed

Knowledge of India

Christianity began to spread in India extensively with the arrival of missionaries during the Medieval and Modern periods. Missionaries opened educational institutions and introduced Western Education in the country.

Jesus's body was placed in a sealed tomb. On the **third day** after his death, his **disciples** found the tomb empty. His followers believed that Jesus had been **resurrected**.

This conviction among his followers led to the emergence of a new community—the **Christian** community. The enemies of Jesus had crucified him, but he lived on in the **hearts and minds** of his followers, not only in

this victory to the divine inspiration of Jesus and made Christianity a **legal religion**. The persecution of Christians thus came to an end.

Think and Answer

TP

Jesus completely rejected the 'eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth' principle. However, in ancient Mesopotamia, this was one of the principles on which Hammurabi's Code of Law was based. Between Jesus and Hammurabi, whom do you support? Explain.

C-4.2

Critical Thinking



Constantine defeated all his rivals and established himself as the undisputed emperor of a unified Roman empire. He declared himself a Christian. The capital was shifted from Rome to **Constantinople**, the site of the ancient city of Byzantium (see map on page 19). It was named Constantinople in honour of Emperor Constantine and it would endure as the Christian capital for 1,000 years.



A statue of Emperor Constantine—he made Christianity a legal religion.

Towards the end of the 4th century Christianity became the **official religion** of the Roman empire. **St Peter's Basilica** (now in Vatican City) became the religious headquarters of the Christian world. The Bishop of St Peter's Basilica, **the Pope**, became the spiritual head of Christians over the world, and was acknowledged as the representative of Christ on earth.



St Peter's Basilica, Vatican City

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Goal 10: Reduced Inequalities

Reducing inequality, within and among communities, is necessary for achieving a better society. Which Christian values can be adopted and applied to promote equality in the world?

C-5.2

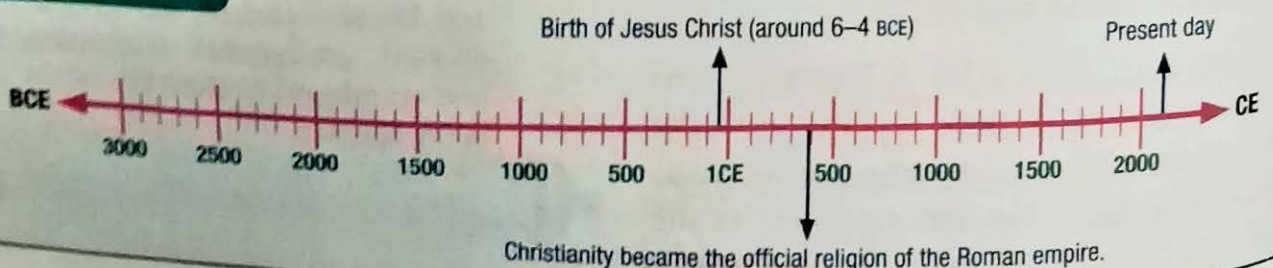
Values and Life Skills

We should learn to be compassionate towards others and show sympathy towards people who are suffering. We should live in peace and try to forgive people who hurt us and win them over with love.

- What are the ways in which you can show compassion towards people who have been victims of serious diseases?

C-5.2

Timeline



Biography

St Peter the Apostle was a disciple of Jesus Christ. He was recognized in the early Christian church as the leader of the 12 disciples and by the Roman Catholic Church as the first of its unbroken succession of Popes. He was a fisherman. He received from Jesus the name Cephas which means a rock. Peter was crucified in Rome in 64 CE during Emperor Nero's rule.



Jesus Christ

He was born to Mary and Joseph in Bethlehem.

He had a divine revelation that he had a mission to fulfil.

His mission was to free people from the bondage of evil and show them the right path.

He gathered twelve disciples and preached his message.

Jesus established a code of conduct based on:

1. unconditional love for God
2. true love for one's neighbour

There was one God who was compassionate, loving and forgiving.

Jesus rejected the 'eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth' principle.

Romans conquered Palestine in the middle of the 1st century BCE.

Jews suffered injustice and oppression.

Jesus's interpretation of Jewish laws clashed with the ideas of the Jewish religious leaders.

Jesus was declared a threat to Roman authority.

Jewish religious leaders felt threatened by Jesus's growing popularity.

Jesus was put on trial and sentenced to death.

He was nailed to a cross and crucified.

Three days later, his tomb was found empty. His followers believed that Jesus had been resurrected.

Rise of Christianity

His message and wisdom attracted large crowds.

It led to the emergence of the Christian community.

The teachings of Jesus Christ were recorded in the Gospels by his four disciples—John, Matthew, Mark and Luke.

Initially, the Christians were a minority in the Roman empire.

In 313 CE, the Roman emperor, Constantine, made Christianity a legal religion.